



The School of Light

Parents raising their own children, together.

Why this exists, what we are building, and what we believe. The longer version, for families who want to know exactly what they would be walking into.

NORTH COAST · NORTHERN IRELAND

From the people behind Days Out NI and the Conscious Parenting NI app

Why this exists

Almost every parent we speak to is living two lives that will not fit together: the one where they provide, and the one where they are actually present.

You go to work. Somebody else has your child for the best hours of the day — the hours when they are rested, curious and at their most themselves. You get the tired end of them, plus weekends, and eleven years later it is done.

Nobody chose that. It is simply the shape that was available. The school day was built around a working day that mostly no longer exists, and the two have quietly drifted apart while everyone kept turning up.

What changed is that a very large number of parents now work from a laptop. The office is wherever they open it. Once that is true, the old trade stops making sense. If you can work anywhere, why would you spend those hours a long drive away from your child?

Providing for them and being present for them should not be two separate lives. That is the actual problem we are solving. Everything else here follows from it.

The obvious alternative is home education, and plenty of families do it well. But the picture most people have of it stops them: one child at a kitchen table with nobody their own age, and one parent trying to be teacher, cook and entertainment for eleven hours a day. That picture is not entirely unfair, and it is exactly the part we are built to fix.

So we are not asking anybody to choose between being there and doing it properly. We are building the third thing — the group, the places, the equipment and the other families that make being there workable.

What we actually are

One group of families, in two parts. Most people start with the first and never necessarily need the second.

RUNNING NOW

The Days Out

Regular days out together for families raising their children the same way. A morning in a park none of you have been to. A coach hired between us to the zoo. Rock pools, forests, farms, workshops.

Weekly, rather than the once a month most groups manage — because friendship needs repetition, for the adults as much as the children.

Easy to join, small cost, nothing long to sign. It fits around school, so weekends and holidays count.

IN PREPARATION

The Facility

A permanent place on the North Coast. A barn set up as an indoor park, a garden, a quiet house, rooms for real work, and a proper work zone for parents.

Open 8am to 8pm, seven days a week. You come and go inside that, however your week actually runs.

A small number of families, a serious monthly commitment, and a much closer fit required. Places go to families we already know from the days out.

The days out are not a marketing funnel for the facility. They are the thing itself, and for a lot of families they will always be enough — particularly for those whose children are happy in school and who simply want better weekends and better friends. The facility is for the families who want this to be the main shape of their week.

Nothing happens without you

Ask a parent what is in their child's curriculum this term and most cannot tell you. It was written by people they have never met, for reasons never explained, and their agreement was never sought — not refused, simply never sought, because the arrangement has no place for it.

Here the plan is made **with your knowledge, with your input and with your consent**, because you are standing in the building while it happens. You know what your child did today because you were there. Deciding what they learn next is a conversation rather than a letter home. And the projects belong to everybody — you are not being briefed on your child's education, you are in it, working on the same things at your own level.

A family that works on things as one unit stays one unit.

Who it is for

Children three to eight, with their brothers and sisters. In school, home-educated, or somewhere in between — all three are welcome, and the mix is deliberate rather than tolerated. The parent comes too. That part does not vary.

What we believe

Five things. Everything else here is a consequence of one of them.

1. The family is the centre. Everything else is supplemental — including us.

A child learns more from the adults who love them than from anybody who is paid to be with them. That is not a complaint about teachers; it is simply where the weight sits. Most of the way we arrange childhood ignores it. We are trying to arrange things the other way round: the family at the middle, and every institution — this one included — arranged around it as support rather than as replacement.

2. Providing and being present should not be two separate lives.

Work is not the enemy of parenting. Distance is. A parent who works three metres from their child, with gaps in the day where they look up and are found, is having a completely different life from one who works thirty miles away and gets an hour at bedtime. We build for the first.

3. Children learn by doing difficult things near people who like them.

Not by being tested. A child who climbs the high frame, leads the game, speaks up, or gets the thing to finally work has learned something a worksheet cannot deliver. Confidence is not praise for existing — it is the residue of having done hard things in front of others and survived it.

4. Asking for help is a skill, not a weakness.

In most classrooms it is called cheating. No adult is ever asked to solve a real problem alone with no help and no resources, so we stop pretending childhood should work that way. Children here ask each other, ask an adult, ask an AI. What is assessed, informally, is whether the thing worked in the end.

5. We are open to the best way.

We are not a method and we are not named after a founder. Montessori got practical work and real tools right. Waldorf got rhythm, materials and beauty right. Forest school got the outdoors right. The classical tradition got character right. We take what holds up and leave the rest, and every practice has to survive the question: why are we actually doing this?

We would rather be right in five years than consistent for a hundred.

How the learning works

A child starting now will spend their entire working life beside machines that recall everything instantly. Being a slower version of that is not a skill.

So the weight goes on the things that hold their value: figuring it out, getting on with people, and finishing what you started.

Tasks, not tests

"Build a remote control car. Now make it get all the way round a loop." Nobody hands over the method. They try it, it fails, they change something, it works. That feeling is the lesson — the car is only the excuse for producing it. Given a goal and no instructions, most children freeze at first. Within a few weeks they stop freezing. That switch, from "tell me what to do" to "I will find a way", is the single most useful thing we can hand them.

Screens that do not agitate

Reading and number work happen on e-ink tablets — paper-like, no backlight, no glow — for a couple of hours a day at most. Films and educational material go on a projector, watched together in a quiet room. What you will not find is a bank of glowing tablets keeping children occupied.

A plan built around these children

We use AI tools to build and rebuild the programme around the children actually in the room: where each one is, what they want next, what they need next. Not a national plan written for an average child who does not exist.

We do not compare

Nobody here is measured against anybody else — not the children and not the adults. People are simply better at some things than others, and a child who is years ahead in one subject and behind in another is not a problem to be corrected. That is what a person looks like.

So you start at the level you are actually at. It is often better to put a subject down entirely for a season while you build another one properly, then come back to it — and when you do you will feel behind, and you will not be, because you were doing something else on purpose.

This is hardest for the parents. Sitting down at level one maths beside your six-year-old takes some swallowing. But you either begin where you are or you do not begin, and children who watch a parent do that learn something no lesson delivers. We publish general guides to what tends to be possible at each age because they are useful for orientation, the way a map is useful. They are not a standard anybody has to meet.

Will they fall behind?

Behind what, is the honest question back. If your child is in school, none of this changes their schooling — it adds friends and better weekends. And for families going further: countries that begin formal schooling at six or seven do not produce children who read worse at eleven. Under seven, play, movement, language and a secure attachment to an adult appear to do more for later ability than early formal instruction does.

What children actually do here

A child is not an apprentice person waiting until twenty-five to begin taking part. They have real value the moment they can do a real thing.

Useful now

As soon as a child can comfortably do something useful, they do it. Gather logs for the fire. Collect the eggs. Feed and care for an animal. Order something at the shop. Chop, stir, lay the table. Tidy and organise. Help clean the car. Look after the building they use every day.

This is not chores as discipline. It is the difference between a person who belongs somewhere and a person who is being hosted there. If the room magically repairs itself every night, a child never learns what it costs to put things back in order — and never values it. Ownership scales outward: your own space, then your family, then the group, then the town you live in. A child who takes care of their own place grows into an adult who takes care of the place around them.

Value for value, at their level

We want children who understand early, and from having done it, that you get by giving something worth having. Not as a lecture about economics — as something they have actually done.

It starts as play: shopkeepers, with real change and a real queue. Then it grows into things that are small but genuinely real.

- ✦ Running a stall at one of our own days out
- ✦ Organising a small event for the group — choosing the place, working out what it needs, then doing it
- ✦ Helping with a fundraiser and watching the money arrive because of work they did
- ✦ Taking a proper job around the building — the food room, the tidy-up, the animals — and being paid for it in something they can spend

That last one is worth doing properly. A simple internal token system, earned for real work and spendable on real things, teaches value-for-value faster than any amount of explaining. A child who has worked for an hour and then chosen what to spend it on has learned something permanent.

And it does not have to stop at pretend

A six-year-old who can describe an idea out loud can build a working app by talking to an AI — the same way the adults around them do. If it is good, why would it not go out into the world for other people to use?

The paperwork is an adult's job. The idea, the work and the reward are theirs.

Waiting until twenty-five to start learning how to provide something other people actually want is a strange choice, when they could start at five and enjoy it.

The way we are with each other

This is the part that decides whether the whole thing works. Not the equipment, not the building — the tone in the room.

A group like this survives on the quality of the adults in it. Not their qualifications: their manners, their curiosity, and their willingness to be part of something rather than a customer of it.

There are always several adults in the room — facilitators and parents both. More adults means more attention, more help, and more people who know your child by name.

What everybody brings

- ✓ Good energy, and a hand with whatever needs doing
- ✓ Curiosity — happy to hear an idea you have not heard before, and to offer one back
- ✓ Kindness towards every child there, not only your own
- ✓ Food you would be glad for any of the children to see you eating
- ✓ Conversation. Parents here are interesting, and that is not an accident
- ✓ Your own mess, taken home with you

What we leave at home

- Smoking or vaping anywhere near the children
- Fizzy drinks, sweets, and the beige-and-orange end of the menu
- Talking down to children — ours or anybody else's
- Turning up to be entertained, and waiting for somebody else to run the day
- Negativity brought in and set down in the middle of everybody else's afternoon

This is not a purity test. Nobody here has it worked out and nobody is keeping score. We are all just trying to be a bit better than we were last year.

The reason any of it matters is that at three to eight, children copy what they see far more than what they are told. Our own example is the curriculum, whether we intend it to be or not. So the standard is about what we model, never about auditing each other.

And you are allowed to work

Nobody expects you to be on top of your children every minute. That is the opposite of the point. Your children will be busy with other children; you can sit at the edge of the play zone with a

laptop and get an hour done, then look up and be found. Presence is not the same as constant supervision, and pretending otherwise is what makes people exhausted.

What the facility will be

Four spaces, each doing one job properly, and a child moving between them as their day requires — loud to quiet, group to alone, inside to outside and back.

The barn

High ceilings, soft floors, and the kind of climbing, swinging and sliding you would drive an hour to find — indoors, so the weather stops deciding. Under seven, a child learns through their body before anything else, so the body comes first and it comes first for as long as they need it.

The garden

Beds to dig, ground to run on, weather to be in. Hours outside on any day that allows it, rather than fifteen supervised minutes at a fixed time.

The quiet house

Beanbags, low light, books, and a projector for something worth watching together. For the child who has had enough noise, and for the afternoon when everybody has.

The work rooms — and the work zone

Big tables for building together, small desks for the child who wants an hour alone, and real tools rather than toy versions of real tools. Next to it, a quiet work zone for parents: good light, proper internet, good coffee, and twenty steps between you and your child.

One table

Everybody eats together, and the food is real. Highly processed food, artificial colours, sweeteners and additives are kept out — not discouraged, kept out. Partly because of what they do to a young body, mostly because of what they do to a room of young children twenty minutes later, and to the child who then gets told off for something the food did. Children help make the lunch. A child who has chopped a carrot has a different relationship with the carrot.

The hours

8am to 8pm, seven days a week. Come for three hours or eleven. Three long days and four days at home. Two mornings a week. Weekends only, if your children are in school. The flexibility is not a perk — it is the reason the place is worth building.

What it is not

- **It is not a registered school.** Children who attend the facility full-time are home-educated, and the legal responsibility for their education stays with their parents. We provide the place, the group, the equipment and the programme. We will walk any family through what electing home education actually involves — for most it is far less complicated than they expect.
- **It is not childcare.** We do not take children off their parents' hands. You are in the building and you remain responsible for your own child, exactly as you would be at a park or a soft play. You may hand that to another adult you personally trust, and that arrangement is yours to make. This is not a technicality — it is the entire design.
- **It is not a religion, and it is not a method.** Families of any faith or none are welcome, and no child here is taught that one worldview is settled fact.
- **It is not a perfect place run by perfect people.** It is a group of families trying to do something better than the default, and improving it as we go.

How you go further

You have applied for a day out. That is the right first step and, for a lot of families, it is the whole thing.

Come along. Meet everybody. Watch your children in the middle of it. Do it a few times and see whether these are your people — because that is a question nobody can answer from a website.

If, after a while, you want this to be the main shape of your week rather than the best part of your weekend, that is a separate and much longer conversation. Applying for a place at the facility is its own process, and it happens with families we already know. There is no way to shortcut it and no advantage in trying, because the whole thing depends on the group being right.

We are not opening on a date. We open when the right families are together — which is not a marketing line, it is the actual condition.

In the meantime

Days Out NI — our free guide to everywhere worth going with children in Northern Ireland.
daysoutni.com

Conscious Parenting NI — the free app with the thinking behind all of this. new-beginnings-livid.vercel.app

Questions, at any point: school@aeonreon.com